Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are connections that form between us and a colour almost by themselves. We are not born with a ready list of “red = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly often. They are usually made up of three layers. **From the body**, **from culture** and from **what we have lived ourselves**.

From the body

Red is the colour of **blood**, **fire** and **a flushed face**. Our body knows it before we start to analyse it. We blush with shame, anger, joy and excitement, and our heart may start to beat faster. That is why life, warmth and energy are easily linked with it – but so is pain. **One colour, two very different sides of the same coin**.

From culture

The heart on a Valentine's card is usually red. So is the “stop” sign. In China red is traditionally the colour of luck and celebration. One single colour thus manages **love**, **prohibition** and **festivity**. **What we read in it also depends on where and in what we grew up**.

From what you have lived

Mum's red lips, the red pencil at school, a first red dress or the car in which something happened that is never forgotten. These are associations with **their own signature**. **Two women can look at exactly the same red** and one feels strength, the other tension. The colour is the same. **The story is not**.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what “red” actually is and what is your own story about it.

A question for you

“What do you connect red with first?”

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Stories

Blood and blushing

Red is the colour of **blood**, **life** and **warmth**. The body knows it before we name it. We blush with shame, anger, embarrassment and excitement, our cheeks burn and our heart speeds up. To blush means that something is going on in us and that it shows.

A red rag to a bull

The saying “it is like a red rag to a bull for me” is known to all of us. **Only the bull does not know about it**. By all accounts it does not perceive red the way we do and will charge at a cloth of any other colour as well. What throws it off is **movement**, **not colour**. The red cloth is tradition and theatre for the audience. It is also often said to hide the blood, but that is not firmly documented.

So the saying is more about us than about the bull. **Red sets something off in us** and we conveniently blame the colour.

Traffic lights and red

Of all visible colours red has **the longest wavelength**. It scatters least in air, fog and smoke, so **it can be seen from the farthest away**. That is why the railways already used it in the 19th century as the “stop” signal.

Red meant danger back then anyway, so it is hard to say what decided more. Optics, or the old link with blood and fire. Red **stops** us and **heats us up** at the same time. Stop, something important is happening here.

Red and eroticism

Why is red light associated with brothels? It is not known exactly. The term “red light district” appears in the American press at the end of the 19th century and there are several explanations. Railwaymen with lanterns, a saloon called Red Light in Dodge City and others.

None of them is confirmed. All that is certain is that the link between red and **physicality**, **desire** and **the forbidden** is old and common in many cultures.

So red is probably not a magic wand. It is more of a **story** we tell about it, and that story is strong.

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